

LIONHEART

THE JOEL LOMNICK STORY

VOLUME 1

VOLUME 1 - TEN-PAGE SNEAK PREVIEW

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The Joel Lomnick Story

A public sneak preview

This ten-page edition presents selected first-person excerpts and lightly condensed transitions from the completed first volume. It is designed to introduce the voice, emotional weight, and movement of the memoir without replacing the full book.

Lionheart: The Joel Lomnick Story, Volume 1

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Published by Lomnick Professional Services - Richmond, Virginia

ISBN 978-1-257-77983-3

Names, events, and experiences are presented as remembered by the author.

Selected for public preview by the author.

"This is not the whole story. It is just the opening roar."

Before the roar

In my world, survival wasn't a choice. It was the rent you paid just to keep breathing. Survival came with rules: don't embarrass your mama in public, don't touch anything in the store, and don't let folks catch you slipping. Those were not suggestions. They were survival codes, passed down like recipes and designed to keep Black kids alive in a world that was not built for us.

My biological family was my first pride. They were the cradle and the crucible - lifting me one moment, testing me the next. Love showed up in discipline, lectures, and side-eyes across the dinner table. Protection was not always soft, but it was steady. Family meant never facing the storm alone, even when the storm was coming from inside the house.

Engineering eventually gave me something the chaos could not: structure. Systems, circuits, and logic did not lie or disappear overnight. If you wired it right, the lights came on. That honesty felt like relief. But no degree, paycheck, or title could answer every question at home. Identity, faith, ministry, and mentorship kept pressing their way into the same life until all of it braided into one name: Lionheart.

*Strong but not stone. Tender but not weak.
Scarred but not silent.*

1981 - ROCHESTER, NEW YORK

Stanley Street: the first blueprint



Cathy and young Joel.

I was born Joel Maurice Lomnick in Rochester, New York, with lungs strong enough to make nurses wince and a mother tough enough to raise me on grit, faith, and an accounting degree. My mother, Cathy, could hold the world up on a small salary and still make you feel like royalty. She helped people find homes, even while fighting to keep one steady for her own boys.

My father, Wilfred, was intelligent, skilled, and proud - an electrician, carpenter, Army veteran, and complicated man. He carried brilliance in one hand and volatility in the other. Loving him meant holding your breath, waiting to see which version of him came through the door.

Stanley Street was crowded, loud, funny, and alive. Laughter, arguments, and Sunday dinner mixed together like gumbo. Family meant sharing space, food, secrets, and sometimes discipline from whoever happened to be closest with the slipper. In that house I learned how to read a room, how to find a corner of peace, and how to shine with almost nothing. Survival was not an extracurricular activity in our household. It was the curriculum.

NOVEMBER 6, 1995 - STERLING STREET

The night childhood ended

November 6, 1995. A Monday night. A school night. Jasen and I were asleep when my mother's scream sliced through the dark: 'JOEY! JASEN! HELP!' We ran down the hall, and when we reached her room, the world split in two. My father was on top of my mother with a butcher knife in his hand. Her shirt was already blood-soaked.

Jasen froze. I was terrified too, but fear did not matter. Survival took over. I launched myself at my father's back and started swinging. I remember thinking he could turn the knife on me at any second. Then another thought came: if I die tonight, I die saving my mother. So be it.

The police report reduced everything to a few bland words. It could not capture the blood on the sheets, my little brother sobbing in the doorway, or the moment childhood ended. The next morning I went to school with my mask in place: good student, funny Joel, the kid teachers wanted in advanced classes. Nobody knew I had fought my own father to keep my mother alive.

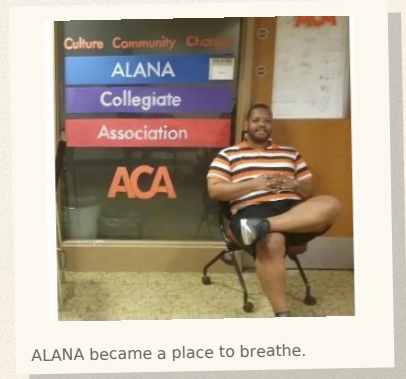


The next morning, I went to school.

At school I was still the scholar, the athlete, and the jokester. Nobody knew what I had fought through the night before.

Trash bags, mini-fridges, and a red D

August 1999. My mother, my brother, and I rolled into RIT like we were staging a heist. Everything I owned was stuffed in trash bags, beat-up suitcases, and boxes patched with tape. Around us, white families unloaded U-Hauls filled with matching dorm sets, televisions, and mini-fridges. Their mothers floated in sundresses. Mine carried exhaustion, pride, and the question written across her face: How long can we afford this?



ALANA became a place to breathe.

We dragged my life up four flights of stairs. My roommate was already unpacked, his clothes folded neatly in matching bins. That was my first taste of independence: trash bags versus mini-fridges.

Then the first red D landed on my desk. Joel 'Most Likely to Succeed' Lomnick stared at it like it belonged to somebody else. Physics, calculus, and programming demanded languages I had not yet learned. I could go entire days without seeing another Black student in class. When I finally found Unity House, it felt like breathing again. The music, laughter, spades tables, and familiar food reminded me that I was not only a dot in a lecture hall. I was part of a people.

The rooms that kept me alive



Gospel Ensemble.



NSBE leadership and family.

If Unity House gave me family and BACC gave me identity, Gospel Ensemble gave me sanctuary. I entered my first rehearsal expecting to watch. Instead, the room shook with harmony, laughter, and survival. Students packed shoulder to shoulder, turning sterile campus walls into a cathedral.

The ensemble became a training ground for leadership. I moved from assistant director to vice president to president, and even took on the website - one of my earliest experiments blending technology with community. Carrying that legacy felt heavy, but holy.

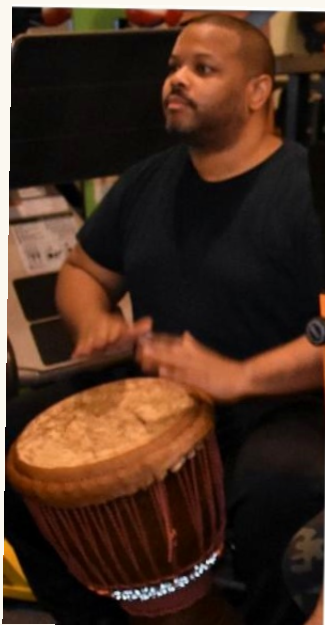
NSBE taught me another form of survival: how to organize, prepare, advocate, and leave the door open behind me. Gospel gave me spirit. NSBE gave me strategy. Together, they helped keep me in school long enough to become the engineer everybody had predicted - and the leader I had not yet imagined.

The drum spoke first

The first time I entered a West African drum and dance rehearsal, the room felt older than the building. The drums were not background music. They were instructions. Every rhythm told the dancers where to land, when to answer, and how to become part of something larger than themselves.

At first I was stiff, worried about looking foolish. Then I stopped protecting myself from the moment. I learned to let the rhythm move through me. Performance became another kind of engineering: timing, structure, repetition, trust - except this system sweated, shouted, laughed, and remembered.

On Sunday mornings, WITR gave me another room. The studio was no bigger than a dorm, but behind the microphone it felt infinite. Elders requested songs, mothers asked for prayer, and gospel traveled into kitchens across Rochester. I learned to let silence breathe and trust that my voice could carry people.



Rhythm became memory, language, and ministry.

A degree did not automatically become direction



Corn Hill, Rochester - reward, refuge, and crossroads.

Graduation should have been a mountaintop, but grief has a way of tinting even the brightest days. My grandmother Marzell died weeks before I finished RIT. I walked across the stage as a first-generation engineer carrying the Lomnick name onto a diploma, and one of the people I most wanted to see it was gone.

I moved into a new loft in Corn Hill and thought the family would celebrate. Instead came the whispers: Why live somewhere so expensive? The irony was painful. I was already helping with the mortgage, car note, and schoolbooks. The loft was proof I had survived. Yet the promised land never arrived. Kodak was collapsing. Engineering work gave me discipline but not direction. Rochester had given me culture, survival, and voice, but it was also suffocating me. By 2007, I understood that staying could become another kind of surrender.

THE ROAD TURNS EAST

Volume 1 ends at the edge of departure.

By 2007, Rochester could no longer hold every version of me. The family story was unfinished. Faith was complicated. Engineering had given me a profession, but not yet a home inside myself. I left my Corn Hill loft in the care of someone I loved like a younger brother, packed what I could carry, and pointed my life toward Troy.

The next chapter begins in Troy.

New city. New household. Same unfinished heart.

Lionheart: The Joel Lomnick Story

Volume 1 - Completed memoir

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Volume 2 - The reinvention years

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